

Using visual conversations to aid in research

A Brief Guide to using visual resources to support individuals with additional needs during the research process

VISUAL CONVERSATIONS

Visual conversations can prepare people with additional needs to express their opinions on important subjects. This system uses symbols to allow them to share their views on a subject. Open-ended questions guide the discussion, giving individuals the chance to place their answers under specific headings.

HOW DO WE DO IT?

STEP ONE;

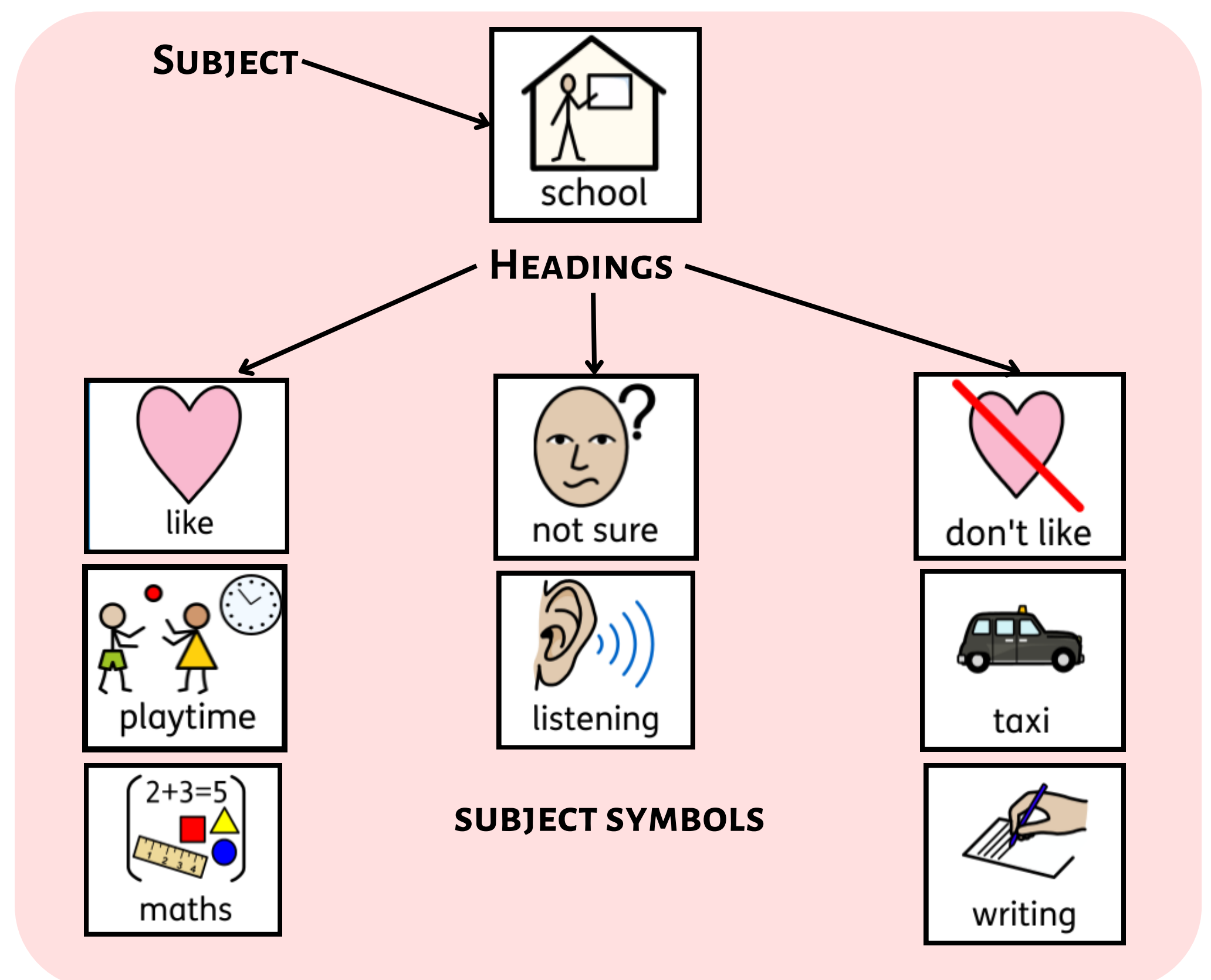
Think about your subject. It should be something you can ask open-ended questions about, like "How do you feel about school?" instead of just "Do you like school?"

Consider what symbols you would need to cover the conversation, for example for a conversation around "how do you feel about school?" you may have symbols for each different lesson, lunchtime, places around school, adults in school and friends.

STEP TWO;

Set out the conversation, there should be;

- Your subject at the top
- Headings that reflects the question/subject being discussed
- Space between each one to enable the individual to put the symbols down



STEP THREE;

Introduce the conversation, e.g. Let's talk about a subject together. I will show you some symbols, and I'd like you to place each one under the heading that you think best represents your feelings about it. Hand the individual each symbol and ask "how do you feel about?..."

STEP FOUR;

When all the symbols have been placed, read them back to the individual and give them the opportunity to make any changes. Have some sticky notes on hand to create new symbols as the conversation goes along.

THINGS TO CONSIDER

- Get an understanding of the individuals level of symbolic representation... would they be better with photographs?
- Consider which symbol set will be most recognisable for them (e.g. Widgit vs PCS)
- Build trust and connection with the individual before having these conversations
- Make sure your headings include a 'neutral' response, such as 'not sure' or 'don't know'
- Work closely with the individual and those who know them best to ensure that the questions/format respect their communication style